



PROGRESS REPORT

South Africa: progress report, August 2025 – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-26-2 · 153 systems and instruments tracked

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY ·
INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS · WHERE THE RECORD IS THIN

This report asks the same set of questions of every country. The rows below are a fixed frame of indicators, one row each, chosen in advance and covering all thirty-eight subjects the base tracks — so what appears here is decided by the frame and not by whichever records happened to accumulate. Each row says what happened on that indicator during the period, with every claim linked to the source it rests on.

Where a row reads *No evidence*, the base holds nothing on that indicator. **That is a statement about this base, not about the country** — it does not mean nothing exists, only that nothing has been collected here yet. The rows that carry evidence say what it is; the rows that do not are left to speak for themselves.

The period is 2025-08-01 to 2026-08-26.

Progress values. *Advanced* — a system entered service, a stage was completed or an instrument was made. *Stalled* — a stated target passed without delivery. *Regressed* — an instrument was withdrawn or neutralised, or a reported position worsened. *Mixed* — the indicator's instruments moved in different directions in the period; the clause after the comma names which moved which way. *No change* — the base holds a standing position and nothing in the period touched it. *No evidence* — the base holds nothing on this indicator at all. A value may carry a qualifying clause after a comma, as in *Advanced, regulations still pending*.

Governance

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Strategies, plans and policies	Digital transformation strategy	The Cabinet-adopted roadmap is unchanged, but Operation Vulindlela's reporting moved from 80% of initiatives on track to uneven and slower than anticipated. The instrument itself did not move. The Digital Transformation of Government Roadmap was approved by Cabinet in March 2025 , before this window opened, and nothing in the twelve months amends, replaces or reviews it. What moved is the account of its delivery. A briefing in April 2026 put 80% of digital transformation initiatives on track with a fifth complete. The quarterly report of July 2026 replaces that with a statement that progress has been uneven and in certain instances slower than initially anticipated , and publishes no later percentage. A quantified claim withdrawn and not restated is a worse position than the one it replaced, whatever the underlying delivery did. Cabinet's own diagnosis of the problem — interdepartmental coordination, outdated systems, overlapping mandates and limited skills — names institutional fragmentation rather than technology.	REGRESSED the roadmap stands and its own delivery reporting withdrew a quantified claim
Strategies, plans and policies	ICT strategy	The communications department tendered on 11 August 2026 for an ICT indicators and scenario-modelling system to steer the digital economy to 2050; nothing is awarded or built. 2026-08-11 — the department put out to tender a system of ICT indicators and scenario modelling running to 2050 , framed against the National Digital Transformation Roadmap, the Presidential Commission on the Fourth Industrial Revolution and the Digital Economy Masterplan. What is tendered is the instrumentation, not the strategy: no award, value or delivery date is published, and the three documents it is framed against are the standing position it would measure. A second monitoring instrument appeared in the same month — the Presidency and the planning department went to the parliamentary committee to fast-track a digital dashboard for mega infrastructure projects , again with no delivery date, data source or custodian named, and no statement of whether it will be public.	ADVANCED a tender for a modelling system rather than a strategy

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Strategies, plans and policies	Broadband strategy	The department tendered a market study toward a Cost to Communicate Roadmap and the regulator consulted an IMT roadmap to 2030, but no auction is scheduled, priced or gazetted. 2026-08-01 — the department put a market analysis study out to tender , conceding in the tender document a current policy vacuum and that the price benefits expected from the 2022 spectrum auction remain largely unmet. It names market concentration, spectrum allocation and the burden on prepaid consumers as the structural causes, and asks for a roadmap of short-, medium- and long-term reforms plus an assessment of the regulator's measures. 2026-07-24 — the regulator gazetted an IMT Roadmap to 2026 with draft assignment plans and opened consultation reaching to IMT-2030 . The roadmap records 794 MHz assigned against 19,625 MHz identified . Against both, the release itself has not moved: the 2026 frequency plan targets 1,145 MHz more mid-band spectrum and over 17,250 MHz of mmWave, but no auction has been scheduled, priced or gazetted . A study of why prices are high and a roadmap of what could be assigned are both downstream of an auction nobody has dated.	MIXED a cost study and a spectrum roadmap advanced while the release they depend on stayed unscheduled
Strategies, plans and policies	Data storage / cloud strategy	The draft National Policy on Data and Cloud remains a draft, unresolved since 2021, and the date of the instrument itself is disputed on the record. The standing position is a draft policy of 2021 that has not been resolved , and the base cannot settle the instrument's own date. Nothing in the twelve months to 2026-08-26 gazettes, withdraws or replaces it. What the draft would do is not small: it declares that data generated in South Africa shall be the property of South Africa and provides for in-country copies for law enforcement. A research organisation warns it could obstruct the cross-border flows the continental free trade area needs, and it sits markedly apart from the adequacy logic the data protection Act already runs on — so the country's cloud position is two instruments pointing in different directions, one of them in force and the other in draft for five years.	NO CHANGE
Strategies, plans and policies	Data interoperability framework / roadmap		NO EVIDENCE

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Strategies, plans and policies	AI strategy	The draft national AI policy was withdrawn in April 2026 over fabricated academic citations, the seven institutions it proposed are under reconsideration, and cabinet has slipped to November 2026 or January 2027. 2026-04 — the draft national policy, released for comment on 10 April 2026, was withdrawn after AI-hallucinated citations were found in its reference list . Two officials were on precautionary suspension as at 19 August 2026 . 2026-05-12 — an expert panel was appointed to advise the redraft. 2026-07-29 — the department stated the replacement will issue national guidelines rather than prescribe rules to industry , and that the seven proposed new institutions are being reconsidered. Parliament's communications committee prefers strengthening the existing regulators through the ICT and Media Regulators Forum to creating them. 2026-05-27 — cabinet consideration moved to November 2026 with January 2027 as the fallback . South Africa has no gazetted national AI policy framework, and the instrument that was in the window went backwards rather than forwards.	REGRESSED
Strategies, plans and policies	Data localisation policies	The only localisation instrument is the same unresolved draft data and cloud policy, which would vest data generated in South Africa in the state. Localisation in South Africa rests on a draft. The draft data and cloud policy declares that data generated in South Africa shall be the property of South Africa and provides for in-country copies for law enforcement ; it has not been gazetted and nothing in the window moved it. What is in force runs the other way. The data protection Act operates an adequacy model — cross-border transfers are permitted where equivalent protection, consent or contractual necessity applies , with the responsible party accountable — so the position a reader would take from the statute and the position the draft policy would create are not the same, and the base holds no decision reconciling them.	NO CHANGE
Strategies, plans and policies	Data governance policy		NO EVIDENCE

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Strategies, plans and policies	Open data policy	A National Open Science Policy is on the books with no commencement date stated; no open data policy of general application is held. The base holds one instrument in this space, a National Open Science Policy , and records that no commencement date is stated for it. Nothing in the twelve months to 2026-08-26 commences, amends or reports against it. It is also narrower than the indicator: an open science policy governs publicly funded research output, not government administrative data. No open data policy of general application, no national portal and no publication duty on departments appears anywhere on this ledger.	NO CHANGE
Legislation and regulation	Data protection legislation	The Act is unamended. The regulator told a webinar on 18 August 2026 it is working with the justice department to amend it to cover artificial intelligence and privacy by design. The statute did not move in the window. What is on the record is an intention: the regulator stated on 18 August 2026 that it is working with the justice department to amend the Act to cover artificial intelligence and privacy by design , and in the same session that it has no capability to test external systems for privacy compliance before launch. The Act's own terms are unchanged and its ceiling is low against the harm it addresses: five years on, the maximum fine remains R10m against an average measured breach cost several times that. No amendment Bill, gazette notice or draft text is held, so this is a stated programme of work rather than a legislative step.	NO CHANGE amendment work on AI and privacy by design is stated and nothing is enacted
Legislation and regulation	Cybersecurity legislation		NO EVIDENCE

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Legislation and regulation	Legislation covering digital id	Draft identification regulations were gazetted on 4 May 2026 and consulted to 6 June, while the National Identification and Registration Bill is still before Parliament. 2026-05-04 – draft amendments to the Identification Regulations were gazetted , with a 33-day comment period closing on 6 June 2026. They would create voluntary digital-ID credentials with legal parity to the physical document , grant accredited trusted entities API access to the population register under data-sharing agreements, and set three assurance levels, seven-year audit logs and private-sector enrolment points, with finalisation dated September 2026. The primary legislation has not kept pace. The National Identification and Registration Bill remains before Parliament , named as the statutory foundation the regulations should rest on, and the record does not say whether its passage is now a precondition. A submission on the closing day asked the department to suspend the regulations pending that Bill, a published digital identity policy and demonstrated compliance with the data protection Act, on the ground that a biometric enrolment and real-time verification system is being built with no formal role for the Information Regulator. That submission is held as a supplied document with no published address, so it cannot be linked here.	ADVANCED the regulations moved ahead of the Bill they are said to rest on
Legislation and regulation	Digital payments legislation	The Treasury and the central bank published a draft crypto asset manual for cross-border activities for comment to 30 September 2026, alongside draft capital flow management regulations. 2026-08-05 – the Treasury and the central bank published a draft crypto asset manual for cross-border activities , setting authorisation and reporting rules for crypto asset service providers and defining what counts as a cross-border crypto flow, with comments due by 30 September 2026 . Behind it sit draft Capital Flow Management Regulations proposed in April 2026, which would replace the pre-approval exchange-control regime with risk-based reporting and carry penalties of up to R1 million, five years imprisonment or both . The Treasury states that the manual was published before it had considered the comments already submitted on the regulations, and that both remain subject to refinement – so what has moved is two drafts, in an order the Treasury itself flags as out of sequence.	ADVANCED
Legislation and regulation	Legislation enabling data interoperability		NO EVIDENCE

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Legislation and regulation	AI legislation / regulations	No rules govern state automated decision-making. What moved instead was litigation over an algorithmic grant eligibility screen and a copyright Bill silent on AI. The position is unchanged and stated as such: the base holds no instrument governing automated decision-making by the state . What the window produced is a court case rather than a rule. The state is appealing a January 2025 judgment that struck down regulations governing the Social Relief of Distress grant , a scheme administered online only and screened by an algorithmic verification system that excluded applicants it read as earning above R624.00; the court found the automation unfairly excluded otherwise eligible applicants, an AI governance organisation was admitted as a friend of the court, and the appeal was set down for 25 August 2026. The one Bill in the window that touches machine learning does so silently. The Copyright Amendment Bill would replace fair dealing with a broader fair use exception and returned to Parliament in June 2026 after the Constitutional Court upheld most of it; it says nothing explicit about generative AI or text and data mining, which imports another country's judicial answer to those questions along with the doctrine.	NO CHANGE
Legislation and regulation	E-commerce legislation		NO EVIDENCE
Legislation and regulation	Statistics legislation		NO EVIDENCE
Legislation and regulation	Access to information legislation	The regulator issued a precedent-setting access-to-information enforcement notice against a private body in June 2026, the first of its kind on the record. 2026-06 — the Information Regulator issued an enforcement notice against a mining company under the access-to-information Act , which the account records as precedent-setting for private bodies. Before this window the base held no enforcement notice of any kind. It is one notice, not a series. The regulator publishes no enforcement register, and the base holds no figure for requests made, refused or appealed under the Act, so what can be said is that the power was used and not how often it is needed.	ADVANCED

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Data protection	Data protection authority	The regulator issued its first enforcement notices of 2026 and took its school-results challenge to the Supreme Court of Appeal after three losses in the high court. 2026-05/06 — enforcement began. The regulator issued its first enforcement notice for 2026 in May , a precedent-setting access-to-information notice against a mining company in June , and a third treating a misdirected email as a reportable breach. 2026-08-17 — it lodged an appeal to the Supreme Court of Appeal over newspaper publication of school-leaving results , having lost three bids in the high court, arguing the education department must release results directly to learners and has no contract or legal basis for press publication. Against that, it stated on 18 August that it has no capability to test external systems for privacy compliance before launch . The reporting rail it depends on has been in place since the mandatory breach-reporting e-portal opened in April 2025 .	ADVANCED
Data protection	National data protection readiness	Notified breaches ran at about 284 a month to November 2025 and about 263 a month in the first quarter of 2026 — broadly flat, on the only series the base holds. 2026-04-14 — the regulator's quarterly figures put notified breaches at roughly 263 a month in the first quarter of 2026, against about 284 a month over April to November 2025 . That is the whole of the national series, and it is broadly flat. What retention practice actually looks like emerged from litigation rather than supervision. An operator told the Constitutional Court that it retains only six months of operational data at a time and that no record links a message to any corresponding return call , so both sides' valuations in a two-decade claim were modelled rather than measured. Courts had twice ordered production, in 2011 and again in June 2020. It is the clearest published statement of what an operator does and does not keep, and no regulator asked for it.	NO CHANGE a flat breach-notification rate and one retention practice tested in court rather than by a regulator
Regional collaboration	Regional policy collaboration	Digitised border systems were made a regional chairship priority on 17 August 2026, with progress to be measured in crossing times rather than agreements signed. 2026-08-17 — one-stop border posts and digitised border systems were named a priority of the country's regional chairship , tied to a corridor trip monitoring system integrating transport, immigration and customs data, to online permitting and operator accreditation, to the electronic travel authorisation, and to a proposed regional tourism visa. The framing is unusually concrete for a chairship priority — progress is to be measured in border-crossing times reduced rather than agreements signed — but the measure has no baseline. No crossing time, target or timetable is published, and the priority and the measure of progress are both the chair's own.	ADVANCED

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Regional collaboration	Regional legal harmonisation	South Africa is recorded as a non-signatory to the Malabo Convention in an August 2026 review, which finds regional frameworks fragmented and cross-border harmonisation weak. 2026-08-14 — a peer-reviewed review of health-data governance across four countries records only one of them as a Malabo Convention signatory, and South Africa as a non-signatory . It finds all four frameworks fragmented, with weak cross-border transfer harmonisation and capacity gaps. The position is a standing one restated, not a change: nothing in the window records a ratification step, a cabinet memorandum or a stated intention either way. What the review adds is that the absence is not peculiar to South Africa but is the regional norm, which is the more useful half of the finding.	NO CHANGE
Regional collaboration	Shared regional infrastructure	The regional real-time settlement system added the kwanza on 27 July 2026, its first currency beyond the rand since 2013. 2026-07-27 — the Southern African regional real-time gross settlement system added the Angolan kwanza . The system had settled in rand alone since 2013, so this is the first widening of the settlement currency in thirteen years. What the base does not hold is what it is worth: no volume, value, participant count or corridor breakdown is published for the system before or after the addition, so the direction is clear and the size of the step is not.	ADVANCED
Regional collaboration	Cross-border data transfers	The revenue service notified an updated arrangement for automatic exchange of customs information with Malawi on 7 August 2026; no go-live date or transfer terms are published. 2026-08-07 — the revenue service notified an updated IT connectivity arrangement with the Malawi Revenue Authority and published a draft rule amendment with it , for a secure electronic platform exchanging customs information in real time, aligned to the World Customs Organisation data model and operationalising a mutual administrative assistance agreement negotiated in 2019. A regional trade body funded delegation attendance and continues to support implementation . What is signed is the connectivity, not the safeguards. No go-live date is stated, and no purpose-limitation, retention or reciprocity terms are published for a real-time flow of trader data between two revenue administrations. The country's general instrument, the data protection Act's adequacy test, is not mentioned in the account either way.	ADVANCED

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Standards	National interoperability standards	The Minimum Interoperability Standards and the government-wide enterprise architecture have an update dated September 2026 and nothing published against it. The standing instruments are the Minimum Interoperability Standards and the government-wide enterprise architecture. The only thing the window records about them is a date: the quarterly reform report carries an update due in September 2026 . Nothing is published, gazetted or consulted in the twelve months, and no conformance requirement, testing regime or department-level compliance figure appears anywhere on the ledger — which matters more than the slipped date, because a standard nobody tests against is a document rather than a standard.	NO CHANGE
Standards	National quality standards		NO EVIDENCE
Standards	Adoption of international standards	The 2026 National Radio Frequency Plan re-bases the allocation table on the ITU Radio Regulations 2024 and aligns to the continental and regional plans. 2026-07-24 — the National Radio Frequency Plan 2026 was gazetted , approved by the minister on 2 July . It re-bases the 8.3 kHz to 3,000 GHz allocation table on the ITU Radio Regulations 2024 , keeps the country in ITU Region 1 with national variations only under the treaty's own reservation article, and aligns to the African and Southern African allocation plans. This is standards adoption in its plainest form: the national table now says what the international one says. 2026-08-03 — a second, quieter adoption. The medicines regulator invited clinical-trial sponsors to report serious adverse events through the World Health Organization monitoring centre's module , routing domestic trial safety data through internationally hosted infrastructure and taking its reporting standard rather than writing one. No pilot duration, participant target, data-residency statement or transition date to mandatory reporting is published.	ADVANCED

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Public debate and participation in policymaking	Non-governmental contribution to national policy	The rights commission published a policy brief on information integrity and a provincial cluster convened a responsible-AI programme after the national policy was withdrawn. 2026-08-19 — the rights commission launched a policy brief on information integrity and human rights , grounded in the constitutional rights to expression, political participation and access to information, with a deputy minister stating that government should not become the custodian of truth on disinformation while the information environment should not be left to private platforms' algorithms. It is a brief rather than an instrument, and no legislative proposal or timetable follows from it on the record. 2026-08-17 — a provincial AI cluster announced a responsible-AI programme with the provincial economic development department , holding its first summit on 25 August 2026 on policy, governance, infrastructure investment and sovereign AI. It was convened after the national department withdrew the draft national AI policy, so what is on the record is non-state and subnational actors filling a gap rather than feeding into a process.	ADVANCED
Public debate and participation in policymaking	Open discussion of government policy	The electoral commission is moving a disinformation code from draft to enforcement before the local elections, binding contestants against campaigning on falsehoods. 2026-08-24 — the electoral commission is moving its updated code of conduct on countering disinformation from draft to enforcement ahead of the local government elections . The existing code is extended to campaign mechanisms on new, digital and social media, and binds political contestants, candidates and their supporters against campaigning on falsehoods, with disinformation defined as false information circulated in the knowledge that it is false. The commission cannot itself find a breach or impose a sanction: where it investigates and forms the opinion that one may have occurred it must refer the matter to the Electoral Court. Alongside the code it is working with large platform companies on self-regulation, so that false content can be referred to them for takedown — which places a private takedown route beside a judicial one, with no published standard governing the first. The draft was gazetted with a comment deadline the commission's own statement dates differently from the notice , and it is a draft rather than promulgated regulations.	ADVANCED

Finance

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Domestic budget appropriations and expenditure	Sustainable domestic financing of digital transformation	The communications department spent R3.61bn of a R3.74bn budget in 2025/26, a near-full draw and the only domestic financing figure the base holds. The one domestic budget figure on the ledger is a spend of R3.61bn against R3.74bn appropriated for 2025/26 , a near-full draw with no prior year on file to compare it against. What it cannot answer is whether the financing is sustainable, because the ledger holds no forward estimate, no capital and current split and no measure of what the money bought. The one place a shortfall is visible is elsewhere in this report: the flagship broadband programme's in-year allocation collapsed and the programme was closed rather than completed, which is a financing outcome that no departmental spend rate would have shown.	NO CHANGE
MoUs and other agreements	Strategic relationships		NO EVIDENCE
New investments	Mobilisation of non-state finance	A fibre group was recapitalised at a combined R8.4bn equity value and a data-centre operator holds a ZAR7.5bn expansion budget; neither discloses money actually raised. 2026-08-24 — new shares were subscribed across three fibre and telecoms companies at a combined after-debt equity value of R8.4bn , with the rollout stated to reach 360,000 connected homes a year within twelve months. The subscription amount is not disclosed: the R8.4bn is the implied equity value of the companies, not the money raised , and the targets are the parties' own. 2026-08-12 — an international data-centre operator reported scaling its Johannesburg facility to 24MW against a ZAR7.5bn South African expansion budget covering that site plus banked land in two cities, with further build-out held pending demand. Both figures are the private parties' own, and neither is a commitment a reader can hold anyone to. Private capital is clearly the larger source of digital investment here than the state budget, and it is also the source the base can measure least well.	ADVANCED

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
New investments	Development-partner project financing	A UK-funded regional science and technology accelerator opened expressions of interest on 11 August 2026, worth up to GBP2.5m to March 2030 with South Africa its primary focus. 2026-08-11 – expressions of interest opened for a Southern Africa science and technology accelerator , up to GBP2.5m over three years to March 2030 with up to GBP400,000 for 2026/27 , covering artificial intelligence and emerging technologies and digital access alongside climate, energy, health and space. South Africa is the primary focus and two neighbouring countries the first year's. It is at expressions-of-interest stage: the fund is resourced but the delivery consortium is not chosen, and contract signature is expected within 2026. The programme therefore has a ceiling and a subject matter and nothing else yet, and it arrived in the final fortnight of this window – so what is reported is an arrival, not twelve months of movement.	ADVANCED

ICT Infrastructure

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Connectivity	Mobile penetration	Virtual-operator subscriptions rose about 43% year on year to roughly 4.4 million active SIMs at end-2025, on an analyst count with no published methodology. The only subscription movement the base holds for the window is at the resale layer. An analyst house put active virtual-operator SIMs at about 4.4 million at end-2025, up roughly 43% year on year and forecast to reach 14.4 million by 2030, placing the country first on the continent. One operator separately reported 5.7 million virtual-operator subscribers on its own wholesale platform for the twelve months to 31 May 2026, which it put at an estimated 80 to 85% share. The two are not a series and cannot be netted: one counts SIMs across the market on an undisclosed method, the other counts subscribers on a single platform. No regulator return and no operator-reported national subscriber figure appears on this ledger, so growth in resale is visible and total penetration is not.	ADVANCED
Connectivity	Internet usage		NO EVIDENCE

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Connectivity	Mobile affordability	Unused bundles must roll over from January 2027, a rule now under review application by two operators; an excise cut is offset by rising device prices. 2026-01-23 — amendment regulations were gazetted requiring unused data bundles to roll over automatically and free of charge at least once , excluding bundles of seven days or less and uncapped, free and promotional bundles, with depletion alerts at 50%, 80% and 100%. They come into force on 23 January 2027. Two operators have filed for review , and the filing date and case number are unestablished. On devices the two forces run opposite ways. The minister credits the April 2025 excise removal with 1.1m additional entry-level units ; against that, African sub-\$100 smartphone shipments fell 34% year on year in the second quarter of 2026 and the continental average selling price rose \$41 to \$202 , attributed to memory and semiconductor demand. A tax cut and a component-cost rise are working on the same price, and the base holds no South-Africa-specific unit or price series to net them against.	MIXED a data-rollover regulation gazetted and under legal challenge while device prices rose against an excise cut
Connectivity	National fibre backbone	The flagship broadband programme was declared ended and the state network merger pushed to FY2028/29, while an amendment Bill on rapid deployment was tabled and a private wholesale 5G network opened. 2026-02 — the flagship broadband programme was declared ended in the Budget Review rather than completed , against a 2022 cabinet target of universal access in 36 months. 2026-04-28 — the state network merger went backwards: the deliverable for the year was a finalised road map, and the plan tabled in March 2026 starts again with a preliminary report and implementation in FY2028/29 . 2026-04-20 — an Electronic Communications Amendment Bill was tabled that would make not-for-profit network services licence-exempt and require a national standard by-law providing a uniform wayleave process; the committee extended written submissions to 21 September 2026 . The regulator separately moved to compel every licensed operator to submit geo-referenced data on all passive infrastructure twice a year , with fines up to R1m. 2026-08 — a privately financed wholesale 5G home-broadband network opened wholesale sales , with the first retail provider due live in September 2026; its chief executive accepted the description that this is the open-access network the state spent a decade trying to licence. No coverage footprint, site count or wholesale price is published, so what entered service cannot be sized.	MIXED a programme closed and a merger deferred while a rapid-deployment Bill and a wholesale network moved
Connectivity	International internet bandwidth		NO EVIDENCE

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Connectivity	Internet Exchange Points	The Cape Town exchange went live at two further data-centre sites in August 2026, reaching six locations while one facility still holds most of its peering. 2026-08-03 — the Cape Town internet exchange went live at two further data-centre sites, taking it to six locations . More sites is the movement; concentration is what the same record shows underneath it. One facility holds 87 of the exchange's 122 networks and nearly every 100 Gbps port, against 208 networks and 10,132 Gbps on the more distributed Johannesburg exchange . Distribution across sites is not the same thing as resilience while a single building carries most of the peering, and the base holds no traffic, outage or failover figure for either exchange to test it against.	ADVANCED
Connectivity	Satellite broadband licensing and availability	The ministerial policy direction was rejected by the regulator and the 30% equity requirement stands, while a distributor deal took the route the Act already allows. An instrument was issued and neutralised inside five months. A policy direction gazetted on 12 December 2025 to unblock satellite licensing was rejected in May 2026 , and the 30% historically-disadvantaged equity requirement stands. The minister publicly backs entry while conceding licensing is the regulator's alone , and at the spectrum hearings the largest prospective entrant pressed the regulator on how that requirement applies to the new gateway and user-terminal licence categories — which the draft does not say. 2026-07-15 — the market entered anyway by another door: a satellite operator appointed a domestic distributor , the acquisition route the Act already permits, while the other large constellation launched in its 27th African country without entering South Africa . 2026-05/08 — the fee rules moved. Draft amendments to the spectrum and fees regulations were gazetted, with oral hearings on 19 and 20 August 2026 covering satellite registration, blanket licensing for terminal networks and protection of radio astronomy; the prospective entrant's representations ask for flat per-licence fees and a ten-year minimum term .	MIXED the licensing framework went backwards while a distribution route opened and fee rules were consulted

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Data Storage	Local data centre capacity (all providers)	Delivered load moved from about 350MW to about 390MW, with one 50MW facility the only completed build of scale in the window. 2026-07-22 — delivered live load moved from roughly 350MW to roughly 390MW . Announced pipeline over the same period would take the national figure several times higher, so the gap between announced and delivered capacity is the finding rather than the increment. 2025-11 — the only completed facility of scale was a Cape Town expansion adding 32MW to reach 50MW . 2026-07-14 — a second operator cleared a municipal planning tribunal for a Cape Town site, which is an approval and not capacity. What the base does not hold is a national register: no regulator or department publishes site counts, capacity, utilisation or grid connections, so every figure here is an operator's or an analyst's.	ADVANCED marginal against announced pipeline
Data Storage	Local data centre capacity (national providers)		NO EVIDENCE
Data Storage	Off-site backup capacity		NO EVIDENCE
Energy	Sufficient energy and water for data centres	The rights commission opened submissions on whether data-centre frameworks meet constitutional obligations, on eleven themes including electricity demand, water use and cooling; submissions closed 30 July 2026. 2026-05-22 — the national human rights commission called for written submissions under its constitutional and statutory powers, to assess whether the legal, regulatory, environmental, governance and industry frameworks around data-centre development meet constitutional obligations and international human rights standards. The eleven themes include electricity demand and tariffs, water use and cooling, environmental and climate impact, electronic waste, land use and community participation. 2026-07-24 — a civil-society organisation announced its submission, which is held as an announcement only: the host serves the document itself to an automated fetch with a refusal and no archive copy exists. 2026-08-22 — the commission's scrutiny was reported as running, with environmental groups warning that the infrastructure required to power the state's artificial-intelligence ambitions carries costs that have not been accounted for. No terms of reference, hearing date or reporting deadline is published, so an inquiry is open and its shape is not on the record.	ADVANCED
Energy	Grid reliability		NO EVIDENCE
Energy	Rural electrification		NO EVIDENCE

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Technical Capacity	Robustness of government hardware and software	Home Affairs downtime fell 61% to 13,867 hours in 2025/26, while the national high-performance computing centre is reported at maximum capacity. 2026-08-11 — a parliamentary reply put nationwide system downtime at 13,867 hours in 2025/26 against 35,426 the year before, a 61% reduction , with provincial gains ranging from 79% to 41%, attributed to a service-level upgrade at the state IT agency, 226 links migrated to fibre and 439 offices running on the identification system. The reply is the fuller record: the population register's own downtime fell only from 14,720 to 11,479 hours, a 22% improvement , which is not the figure the department led with. 2026-08-05 — the other direction. A committee oversight visit reported the national high-performance computing centre at maximum capacity and available infrastructure insufficient for future growth . 2026-08-24 — and the estate below both: a fifteen-year tender for inmate communications across 243 correctional centres states the existing copper telephony has deteriorated beyond support. No contract value is published and nothing is awarded.	MIXED front-office downtime fell sharply while the national computing pillar hit its ceiling
Technical Capacity	Local capacity to maintain, manage and develop government systems	An investigation into the state IT agency reported R2.07bn of irregular expenditure across four audited years and annual performance achievement of 42.86%. 2026-07 — a public service commission investigation into the state IT agency reported R2.07bn of irregular expenditure across four audited years and governance weaknesses , with annual performance plan achievement of 42.86% in 2024/25. The agency is separately described as slowing government technology rollout . The 30-day deadline for a recovery plan expired inside this window and no plan is on the record. The agency is the shared capability every department's systems depend on, so a finding of this size against it is a statement about the state's ability to build and run its own systems rather than about one entity's audit outcome.	REGRESSED

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Cybersecurity	National cybersecurity readiness	The national supercomputer was breached and remediated, the national CSIRT publishes no incident statistics, and no national measurement was repeated in the window. 2026-05 — the national high-performance computing centre suffered unauthorised access and the deployment of crypto-mining malware , attributed in an August written reply to vulnerabilities in the legacy system, with ageing components no longer fully supported by their vendors. A remediation and resilience programme has since run across access controls, privileged-access management, network segmentation, patch management and monitoring , with an internal accountability review still running. No cost, data-loss finding or outage duration is stated and the account is the department's own. 2026-08-04 — the national CSIRT is operating, coordinating and routing reports rather than resolving them, on weekdays from 08:00 to 16:30 with no published out-of-hours capability . As at that date it published no incident statistics, advisories archive, annual report or data downloads. The national measurement has not been repeated: the 2024 surveys remain the last , on breaches and on the skills gap . One firm's caseload put ransomware dwell time at 18 days in 2025 against 117 in 2024 — faster attack execution rather than improved defence, and not a national series.	MIXED a breach at the national computing centre and no re-measurement, against a remediation programme and a training tender

DPI

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Data Exchange	National data exchange system	The national data exchange pilot was nine months into a one-year term and onboarding further technical capacity, with no date set for the rollout decision it was to trigger. 2025-10-09 — a one-year Treasury pilot launched , built on the Estonian data-exchange design: a federated real-time sharing rail rather than a central repository . 2026-07 — nine months in, it was onboarding additional technical capacity to support completion . The pilot's own term expires within weeks of this window closing and the base holds no date for the rollout decision it was meant to trigger, no participating-department count and no volume of records exchanged. A pilot that reaches its end date still adding capacity is the shape this row records, and the direction is upward with the deadline arriving first.	ADVANCED stalling

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Data Exchange	Use of digital id in other systems	Biometric verification of grant recipients against the population register reached 997,379 of 19.05m recipients by March 2026, about five per cent. Compulsory for new applications from September 2025, biometric verification against the home affairs register had reached 997,379 of 19.05m recipients by March 2026 , against 42,000 in its first two weeks. That is about five per cent of the recipient base after seven months, so the mechanism works and the coverage does not yet mean much. It is also the clearest instance on this ledger of one state system drawing on another's identity data across a whole population, and the base holds no statement of the legal basis, the error rate or what happens to a recipient the check fails.	ADVANCED partial
Data Exchange	Interoperability of health systems	The health interoperability architecture remains the gazetted 2021 normative standards framework, with no implementation measurement held and the Act it underpins before the Constitutional Court. The architecture is defined inside a gazetted 2021 normative standards framework for interoperability in digital health rather than in a document of its own: a federated hybrid of local and shared infrastructure, with central patient, provider and facility registries, shared clinical repositories and a national health information exchange, built on the international profile and messaging standards. It superseded the 2014 framework and states that semantic interoperability remains an ongoing undertaking with value sets to be published in due time. Nothing in the window measures what it delivered. The insurance scheme it underpins is in its second phase to 2028, its Act is under constitutional challenge with judgment reserved since May, and the national patient registration system is still being built .	NO CHANGE
Data Exchange	Interoperability of education systems		NO EVIDENCE
Data Exchange	Interoperability of social protection systems	The Public Protector found the student funding scheme insufficiently integrated with home affairs, social security and revenue data, and gave the board 30 days to produce a plan. 2026-08-18 — the Public Protector found the student funding scheme's systems insufficiently integrated with the home affairs, social security and revenue data sources it needs to verify students , and directed a digital modernisation and systems-integration plan within 30 days covering institutional integration, verification interfaces, fraud controls and cyber security, elimination of duplicate applications and manual workarounds, student-facing case tracking and costed milestones. The report draws on a 2023 investigation that found some 40,000 non-qualifying students funded to more than R5.1bn, and records that the scheme cannot resolve 80% of contact-centre queries without internal escalation . What has advanced is an order with a deadline attached; no plan, integration or interface is on the record.	ADVANCED an integration plan ordered rather than built

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Digital Identity and CRVS	Robustness of system	Every stated date moved: hosting is now 31 March 2027 and credentials 2027/28, and the digital driving licence's nearest milestone is March 2027. The schedule slipped at every stated milestone. A deadline of April 2025 for cabinet approval of the legal framework was missed; the roadmap milestone of a functional digital identity by the end of the 2025 financial year was missed; the President told Parliament in February 2026 that digital identity would launch during 2026; and the department's own plan, tabled six weeks later, put hosting at 31 March 2027 and operation at 2027/28 . The plan's only target for 2026/27 is the hosting infrastructure itself , with verifiable credentials via a digital wallet in 2027/28 and digital identity and e-passports by 2029. Core identity and PKI infrastructure is to be hosted within the revenue service's environment , with the central bank integrating on payments and know-your-customer checks, and facial recognition primary with fingerprints secondary. The digital driving licence moved the same way: promised for 2026, its nearest dated milestone is now March 2027 .	STALLED
Digital Identity and CRVS	Registration of entire population	Smart identity services ran at 410 bank branches by 13 August 2026, with 574,371 applications processed through banks, against 30 branches a year earlier. 2026-08-21 — a departmental reply to Parliament put 410 bank branches live as at 13 August 2026 and 574,371 applications processed through banks , against 30 branches across five banks in August 2025. The department commits to at least 200 more and states a possibility of 750 branches during 2026/27, and separately to modernising 75 of the 145 remaining unmodernised local offices this financial year. A public branch locator is published . 2026-01-28 — issuance itself set a record: 4,002,964 smart identity documents in 2025, up 17% . The branch counts do not form a series — 372 and 408 appear a week apart in August before the 410 in the reply — and the 750 is a possibility stated to Parliament rather than a target. This is the largest measurable delivery in the twelve months, and it is a channel expansion rather than a new system.	ADVANCED
Digital Identity and CRVS	National maintenance of id and credentials systems		NO EVIDENCE

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Digital Identity and CRVS	Authentication	The online verification service is running with its fee under review litigation, and no accuracy, volume or uptime measure for it is held. The standing position is an online identity verification service in operation, with its fee the subject of a review application . Nothing in the twelve months to 2026-08-26 resolves that litigation or changes the service. What the base does not hold is any measure of it: no query volume, no match accuracy, no uptime and no list of which institutions consume it. The one adjacent movement is in the draft identification regulations, which would grant accredited trusted entities interface access to the population register under data-sharing agreements — a second authentication route, not yet made, and reported under the legislation indicator rather than here.	NO CHANGE
Digital Identity and CRVS	Digital id from birth		NO EVIDENCE
Digital Identity and CRVS	Interoperability of birth registration and digital id		NO EVIDENCE
Digital Identity and CRVS	Use by other systems		NO EVIDENCE
Digital Payments and Fintech	Governance role of central bank	The central bank ruled out non-bank shareholding in the payments utility it half-owns and restated that a retail digital currency has no compelling case. 2026-07-31 — the Governor told the Bank's ordinary general meeting that it would have preferred to hold all of the payments utility and is not looking at bringing others in , having acquired 50% in October 2025. The installed base around it was put at 39 participating banks and more than 480 non-bank payment service providers. 2026-06 — on digital currency the position hardened rather than moved: the Bank's published view is that a retail central bank digital currency has no compelling case yet and the everyday rails come first , with its wholesale distributed-ledger work confined to two completed projects. Both are the same posture from two directions — the central bank taking ownership of the shared retail rail while declining to issue a retail instrument of its own.	ADVANCED

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Digital Payments and Fintech	G2P functionality	Grant card migration reached 172,146 of 463,836 replaced by 28 July 2026, and a state payment credential and wallet entered active development with testing dated November 2026. 2026-07/08 – of 463,836 active gold cards at 29 April 2026, 172,146 had been replaced by 28 July and 264,263 remained , roughly 40% of them in two provinces, against a deadline of 31 August 2026 . The bank reports 306 replacement sites against a target of 300 plus nine mobile teams, ring-fences customers more than 30km from a site, and plans the rollout from monthly data on where each customer last transacted. 2026-07-31 – the state's own rail moved: the payments modernisation programme passed from conceptual design into active development of the payment credential, wallet, governance and trust capabilities, with testing against government use cases dated November 2026 . The base holds no statement of how the state credential is meant to relate to the bank-owned rails it would sit beside, which is the question a G2P wallet raises before it raises any other.	ADVANCED
Digital Payments and Fintech	Revenue collection	The revenue service published a VAT modernisation consultation paper proposing electronic invoicing, an interoperability framework and electronic reporting, with feedback due 16 October 2026. 2026-08 – the revenue service released a VAT modernisation consultation paper proposing a digital VAT model combining electronic invoicing, an interoperability framework and electronic reporting, aimed at moving administration off manual processes and retrospective verification and into the systems businesses already run. It follows a 2023 discussion paper and is stated as building blocks rather than a decided design. The fuller account describes a five-corner model moving toward VAT auto-assessment, with a phased rollout from 2026/27 and stakeholder feedback due 16 October 2026 . It is a consultation paper, not a rule: no cost to business, exemption threshold, accreditation regime for service providers or legislative vehicle is stated. What has advanced is a published design intention on the largest transaction flow the state touches.	ADVANCED

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Digital Payments and Fintech	B2B and B2G functionality	A rand-backed stablecoin was listed on 7 August 2026 and integrated into a merchant payments infrastructure twelve days later, on the issuer's own account of use. 2026-08-07 — a rand-backed token was listed on a global exchange for customers in four African countries , issued by an authorised financial services provider with a domestic asset manager holding the reserves and a monthly attestation. 2026-08-19 — a merchant payments provider integrated the token into its infrastructure, letting its commerce partners make and receive payments in it . Two things the record makes plain and one it does not. The quoted pairs are against dollar tokens, so the on-chain liquidity of the rand token is denominated in someone else's currency; and the account of growing merchant use is the issuer's own, with no transaction count or value published. Whether any of it is business-to-business volume rather than listing activity, the base cannot say.	ADVANCED
Digital Payments and Fintech	P2P, P2G and P2B functionality	The instant payment rail reached 905m cumulative transactions by May 2026, a national QR code standard reached a v1.2 eight-bank cohort, and merger conditions opened one bank's rail to third parties. 2026-05 — the instant payment rail went from 461m cumulative transactions in March 2026 to 905m by May and pivoted toward merchants , having passed R100bn in value . Payments is the fastest-moving part of this ledger by a wide margin. 2026-07 — a national payment code standard reached version 1.2 with an eight-bank test cohort . 2026-08-06 — the competition authority recommended approval of a bank's R400 million acquisition of a payment provider subject to behavioural conditions : the merged entity must make its pay service available to third-party providers technically and commercially capable of integrating with it, may not use confidential information obtained through that access to compete against them, and must treat competing rails no less favourably unless objectively justified. Access to a dominant rail is being set by merger condition rather than by rule, which is a different thing from an access regime and binds only one party.	ADVANCED

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Digital Payments and Fintech	Population uptake	One bank reported digitally active customers up 10% to 3.8m against 9.9m total, and a city is removing cash from six service counters with no stated route for the unbanked. 2026-08-18 — a large bank's interim results put digitally active personal and private banking customers at 3.8m, up 10%, against 9.9m total customers in that segment , with total technology spend of R8,779m for the half, up 7% and 28% of group expenses. These are one institution's figures, reported group-wide across seventeen countries, so they bound the cost and pace of migration at a single bank and not the sector. 2026-08-21 — a second bank reported 581 self-service kiosks handling more than half a million transactions a month across over 60 services, dispensing almost 70% of its instant-issued debit cards, 56% of them to entry-level clients . 2026-09-01 — uptake seen from the other side: a city is extending a cashless pilot to three further service offices, so cash is no longer accepted at six counters . No figure is published for how many residents at those counters paid in cash before the change, and nothing is stated about an alternative for the unbanked — which is the whole of the inclusion question a cashless counter raises. No regulator series covers any of this.	ADVANCED
Digital Payments and Fintech	Cross-border functionality	A domestic bank went live on China's cross-border payment system in November 2025 and was jointly authorised as renminbi clearing bank for Africa in June 2026. 2025-11-20 — a domestic bank went live and was inaugurated at the central bank as the first African direct participant in China's cross-border interbank payment system , with the central bank's governor, the People's Bank governor and the system's chairman present. It was accredited in April 2025 and licensed in June . 2026-06-26 — the same bank and a Chinese counterpart were jointly authorised as renminbi clearing bank for Africa , with operational capacity in the nineteen African countries where the group operates. It is the first clearing bank named after a continent and the first jointly operated by two commercial banks. Two qualifications the record carries. The nineteen countries are not enumerated in either account. And the designation was made by one foreign central bank, with no African regulator party to it — a continental clearing arrangement constituted entirely outside the continent's own institutions.	ADVANCED

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Digital Payments and Fintech	Consumer protection	Enforcement rose to 140 public warnings and R2.89bn in penalties in 2025/26, while the licensing regime for crypto providers is stated not to reach decentralised finance. 2026-07/08 — the conduct regulator's fourth actions report put 140 public warnings and R2.89bn of penalties on 76 persons for 2025/26, against 107 warnings and R119.8m the year before . Most warnings concerned unregistered providers promoting investment offerings on social media, and about 20% involved impersonation of licensed institutions, the regulator and its own staff among them . The penalty jump is driven by one deepfake-advertising matter of over R2bn, whose reconsiderations were pending at the report date, so the total is not a run rate. 2026-08-11 — the perimeter is stated and it has a hole in it: licensing of centralised crypto-asset service providers is in force, but the regulator says the model has no purchase on decentralised finance — protocols with no company, board or natural person to hold accountable — and plans to attach obligations elsewhere. No instrument for that is published. 2026-04 — separately, amendment regulations shifted the anti-spam duty in direct marketing to the consumer commission .	ADVANCED
Registries	Population register	A biometric intelligent population register was announced, while blocked identity numbers fell only from 384,189 to 377,060 in roughly seven months. 2026-06 — the successor was announced: biometrics for every person, the green identity book to be de-recognised and the traffic registration number abolished, under a cabinet approach to migration management. A biometric case-management system and 600 handheld readers have been tendered . The framing is migration control rather than service delivery, which is worth recording about a register the whole identity system rests on. 2026-07-17 — the existing register's known defect barely moved: blocked identity numbers fell from 384,189 to 377,060, 7,129 in roughly seven months, with unserviceable addresses given as the obstacle. Against 702,267 at judgment and a court deadline running to March 2027, that rate does not reach the deadline. A new register announced while the old one's exclusions clear at a thousand a month is the shape of this row, and the base holds nothing on how the two are meant to meet.	MIXED a biometric successor announced while the blocked-record backlog barely moved

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Registries	Civil register	360,000 identity documents sat uncollected at the end of July 2026, on the department's own statement; the base holds no prior figure to compare. 2026-07-31 — the department opened every office nationwide for the final voter registration weekend, stating that 360,000 identity documents sat uncollected . A valid document is a precondition of registering to vote, so the count is a measure of exclusion and not of stock control. It is a first count. No prior figure, no breakdown by office or province and no statement of how long the documents have been waiting is published, so the direction cannot be stated and the level can. Separately, a court found statutory exclusions from birth registration unconstitutional within the window, which goes to the same register from the entry end rather than the collection end.	NO CHANGE a first count with no earlier figure behind it
Registries	Address register		NO EVIDENCE
Registries	Business register		NO EVIDENCE
Registries	Social protection register		NO EVIDENCE
Registries	Electoral register	Voter registration opened inside a messaging platform on 4 August 2026 and carried 1.7m transactions over the final weekend, with 291,016 first-time registrations. 2026-08-04 — the electoral commission launched voter registration inside a messaging platform three days before the deadline for the November local elections , running one-time-password authentication, document upload, address verification and voting-station confirmation over it. The final weekend carried 1.7m registration transactions and 291,016 first-time registrations, of which the online portal alone carried 238,000, and 46% of new registrations were by people under 29 . Two absences accompany the launch: no statement on data handling, and none on a fallback if the channel fails. A national register accepting enrolment through a private messaging platform, stood up three days before a deadline, is a delivery achievement and a dependency in the same act.	ADVANCED
Registries	Tax register		NO EVIDENCE
Registries	Land register		NO EVIDENCE

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Sectoral management information systems	Health	The national digital health strategy's term expired in 2024 and no successor is held; nothing in the window replaces or reports against it. The standing instrument is a national digital health strategy for 2019 to 2024 , whose term has expired with no successor on the base. It set nine strategic interventions, proposed a national grant for digital health targeting three to five per cent of health expenditure, and committed to a master patient index for all South Africans, conformance testing of all health information systems and a review of digital-health governance by 2020. The base holds nothing measuring what any of it delivered, and nothing in the twelve months to 2026-08-26 replaces it. A strategy two years past its term, with no successor and no evaluation, is the position — and the interoperability architecture reported separately under health systems is doing the work a current strategy would otherwise carry.	NO CHANGE
Sectoral management information systems	Education	The student funding scheme was placed under administration with ICT named its largest operational risk — fragmented, manual and not fit for purpose, on the administrator's own words. 2026-08-07 — the administrator's stabilisation plan states that ICT is the scheme's biggest operational risk, as it is fragmented, manual and not fit for purpose . The same submission reports 66 major audit findings and a disclaimer audit opinion, 115 overdue internal audit findings and nine material irregularities, five of them data or systems defects. The scheme was placed under administration in May 2026, its board having been dissolved in 2024 over IT-system failures, and the governance failures were referred for investigation. At provincial level a longer-standing system held its position: online school admissions for the 2027 intake opened on 5 August 2026 , a system running since 2016 that carries a documented record of concurrency failures under load, learners unplaced at the start of the academic year and manipulation by officials, with a better system framed as a future intention.	REGRESSED

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Sectoral management information systems	Social protection	420,000 grants were flagged and roughly 160,000 recipients did not complete review, with child-grant recipients reporting months without payment. 2026-07 — review scope widened and access narrowed in the same movement. Some 420,000 grants were flagged during 2025/26 and roughly 160,000 beneficiaries did not complete the review , with child-grant recipients reporting months without payment; the same crackdown is reported as delaying payments . The mechanism that would settle whether any of this is lawful was neither implemented nor decided inside the window: a bank-account means test applied across eight grants is under appeal, with a hearing on 25 August 2026 . A verification programme is doing what it was built to do and a sixth of those it touched fell out of payment while it did. Both halves are on the record and neither is disputed, which is why this row is Mixed rather than either one of them.	MIXED verification widened while access narrowed
Sectoral management information systems	Justice	The courts digitisation project was referred to the special investigating unit after the contractor denied the department access to its own records. 2026-08-13 — the justice minister referred the courts digitisation project to the special investigating unit and the police priority crimes unit after the contractor denied the department access to its own records at the Master of the High Court in Pretoria . Records storage has been outsourced to that contractor since 2021 across three provinces. No contract value, term, custody arrangement or data-protection provision for the outsourced court records is held. A department locked out of its own records is a custody failure before it is a procurement one, and it is the sharpest instance on this ledger of the state holding neither the system nor the data it depends on.	REGRESSED
Sectoral management information systems	Tax	A modernisation programme was announced in April 2026; the base holds no scope, budget or delivery date for it, only a second-hand account. 2026-04 — a revenue service modernisation programme was announced , reaching the base only through a professional services firm's sector report rather than through the service's own publication. That is the whole of what is held: no scope statement, budget, delivery date or architecture. What is better evidenced is the automation inside the existing system, reported under artificial intelligence in government administration, and the VAT design work reported under revenue collection — so the tax estate is moving in two documented places and the programme said to contain them is not documented at all.	ADVANCED

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Sectoral management information systems	Customs	A real-time customs data platform with Malawi was notified on 7 August 2026, aligned to the international data model, with no go-live date stated. 2026-08-07 — the revenue service notified an updated IT connectivity arrangement for automatic exchange of customs information with a neighbouring revenue authority, and published a draft rule amendment with it . The platform is to exchange customs information in real time, aligned to the World Customs Organisation data model, operationalising a mutual assistance agreement negotiated in 2019. What this indicates about the domestic customs system is indirect but real: the service is able to expose real-time customs data to an external party, which is a statement about its own systems. No go-live date is stated, and the base holds no separate account of the domestic customs platform, its coverage or its performance.	ADVANCED
Sectoral management information systems	Land		NO EVIDENCE
Other GovTech and e-Gov	e-government services	The single citizen application reached a production-ready pilot with a stable platform due September 2026, and the electronic travel authorisation went live at four airports. 2026-08-03 — the single citizen application progressed from proof of concept to a production-ready pilot with governance arrangements in place , with the stable platform, the first credential use case and a shared government platform all targeted for September 2026 and further departmental use cases for March 2027. Public access had been promised for the first half of 2026 in the February 2026 address , so the platform advanced and its date slipped in the same window. The first credential is a digital school-leaving certificate, in testing with the certifying body. 2026-08-12/16 — the electronic travel authorisation went live at four airports and was launched by the President , with full visa-type rollout targeted by end-2026 . The department publishes no statistical series for it and the bases do not reconcile: 88,033 applications to January 2026 in a parliamentary reply, over 75,000 processed with nearly 4,500 rejections at the May budget vote , 203,000 processed by July, and 6,126 rejections put at 2.8% of pilot submissions in August.	ADVANCED

Digitalisation

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Digitalisation of sub-national government	ICT infrastructure for local government	A province launched an AI-evaluated infrastructure platform and opened a funding-matching platform to small business; no municipal-level system is on the ledger. 2026-07-30 — a provincial government launched an infrastructure platform that evaluates projects automatically against treasury rules and a quality standard via an AI agent , reporting an evaluated pipeline of 52 projects worth R132bn with 11 worth over R20bn to be released to market, and memoranda signed with four national and academic bodies. 2026-08-12 — the same province opened free access for small and medium enterprises to a matching platform covering over 300 funders and 600 finance products . The platform is a private one and the counts are its own; the same data put 65.3% of provincial applicants as unable to supply their latest financial statements , which says more about the constraint than the platform does. Both are provincial. The base holds no municipal ICT system, no municipal ICT expenditure data and no local-government digitisation programme at all, so what is advancing sits one tier above the one this indicator asks about.	ADVANCED both instances provincial rather than local
Digitalisation of sub-national government	Digitalisation of local government records		NO EVIDENCE
Rural digital data capture	Digitalisation of rural health clinics		NO EVIDENCE
Rural digital data capture	Digitalisation of rural primary schools		NO EVIDENCE
Rural digital data capture	Digitalisation of rural registry offices		NO EVIDENCE
Rural digital data capture	Digitalisation of rural police stations		NO EVIDENCE

Technology

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
AI	Use of AI in government administration	A public-service chatbot launched on 31 July 2026, the revenue service automates all verifications and 88.41% of complex audits, and travel screening by machine learning is intended. 2026-07-31 — the public service department launched a citizen and public-servant chatbot built on an open-weight model family under a partnership with the model's owner and a local supplier , providing policy, circular and legislation lookups in nine official languages, explicitly decision-support with no decision-making authority. 2026-07-27 — the revenue service reports automated selection covering 100% of verifications and 88.41% of complex audits . At the border, 85% of travel-authorisation applications are assessed automatically against a 24-hour target and 40 document-authenticity parameters , with no appeal route, accuracy rate, disparate-impact testing or human-review threshold stated. The department has stated an intention to screen travellers for fraud using machine learning , with no system, procurement, legal basis or accuracy measure published. Automated decision-making expanded through the whole period without a governing framework, and the only test of it is the litigation reported under AI legislation.	ADVANCED and ahead of any rule governing it
AI	Use of AI in sectoral management information systems	One bank reports over 39,000 staff, 72% of its workforce, as active generative-AI users; another, a chatbot handling over 100,000 queries a month from about 1.6 million users. 2026-08-17 — a large bank reported more than 39,000 staff, 72% of its workforce, as active generative-AI users on a multi-model enterprise platform hosted on a foreign cloud provider , naming relationship management, servicing, payments and lending as priority areas. 2026-08-20 — a different institution reported an agentic chatbot handling over 100,000 queries a month from about 1.6 million users in the first half of 2026 , alongside 30,000 employees a month on a vendor productivity assistant, more than 3,800 staff-built automation agents in production and over 1,400 developers on AI-assisted coding tools. The two are separate institutions and are not comparable with each other. Both are the banks' own figures for adoption, not for automated decisions or customer-facing outcomes, and neither states a model inventory, an assurance process or any customer disclosure. The country holds no AI incident or assurance register against which any of it could be checked.	ADVANCED on the banks' own figures
AI	Development of national / regional AI systems		NO EVIDENCE

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
AI	Control of AI abuse	The medicines regulator requires every AI-enabled device to be authorised before use, and the prudential authority has embedded AI into bank supervision with a framework only expected. 2025-09-26 — the medicines regulator issued requirements for AI and machine-learning enabled medical devices : every such device must be authorised before use and its importer or manufacturer licensed, with higher-class applicants required to produce prior approval from a reference jurisdiction or international prequalification plus local clinical evidence including subgroup analysis by sex, age and ethnicity. It also states that product registration has not commenced, that AI-specific pathways are still to be developed, and that it awaits international guidance before adopting predetermined change-control plans — so the rule exists and the gate it describes is not yet open. 2026-07-16 — in finance, supervision moved before rulemaking : the prudential authority's annual report embeds AI, cloud, cyber and data-offshoring into bank supervision and ran a first nationwide AI-adoption survey, naming regulatory uncertainty, AI skills and governance as the barriers. A dedicated AI-in-finance regulatory framework is expected within 2026 and is not published.	ADVANCED supervisory practice moving ahead of any published framework
ICT Industry	National capacity in DT-related production	The third operator reported R12.64bn revenue and R4.16bn profit, while the sector's B-BBEE council had its chair replaced after being found dysfunctional. 2026-08-24 — the third mobile operator reported R12.64bn revenue and R4.16bn profit after tax for the year to 31 May 2026, a prepaid base past 8 million and a wholesale virtual-operator base of 5.71 million . It runs an asset-light model on other operators' radio networks, so the growth is a virtual-operator business rather than network build — as its 5G service, live from 21 August 2026, makes plain: it claims the widest coverage in the country by roaming on both larger operators' sites rather than owning radio infrastructure . 2026-08-19 — a listed payments company consolidated a division selling near-real-time item-level intelligence on the informal retail economy, drawn from a point-of-sale network of over 90,000 spaza shops and taverns and 10,500 checkouts . The network figures are the company's own, and no consent basis, pricing or data-protection assessment for reselling merchant transaction data is stated. 2026-08-14 — against both, the minister replaced the ICT sector transformation council's chairperson after a departmental investigation found the council dysfunctional . The investigation report is not published and no remedial plan or date for a permanent appointment is stated.	MIXED operators and a data product advanced while the sector's transformation council was found dysfunctional
Innovation ecosystem	Technology hubs		NO EVIDENCE

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Innovation ecosystem	Tech startup ecosystem	Venture funding fell from \$335.9m across 42 ventures in 2025, leading the continent, to fourth place at \$83m in the first half of 2026. Funding reversed inside the window. The country raised \$335.9m across 42 ventures in calendar 2025 on a measure its publisher describes as a minimum floor, leading the continent . 2026-07-27 — in the first half of 2026 it ranked fourth at \$83m, as continental deal count fell 42% year on year and early-stage activity thinned . The two halves are not strictly comparable — a full year against a half — but the ranking is, and first to fourth on the continent in six months is the finding. No domestic count of hubs, incubators, registrations or exits appears on this ledger to set against it, so the only visible measure of the startup base is the money going into it.	REGRESSED

Capacity

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Literacy	Digital literacy (civil service)	The public service department tendered in August 2026 to build a training programme for departmental information security officers across the public sector. 2026-08-17 — the public service and administration department put out to tender the construction of a training programme for departmental information security officers across the public sector , to implement the directive on public service information security. No officer count, curriculum, budget or compliance deadline under that directive is stated, so what the tender implies about the current state — that the officers exist and the training does not — is the most it can be read to say. It is the only civil-service digital capability instrument anywhere on this ledger, and it addresses one specialist role rather than the service's general digital literacy.	ADVANCED
Literacy	Digital literacy (general population)		NO EVIDENCE
Training and skills	DT-related training in secondary education	A vendor academy and a provincial education department agreed to take networking, cyber security and AI courses into 235 schools from February 2027. 2026-08-18 — a networking vendor's academy and a private group agreed with a provincial education department to take networking, cyber security and artificial-intelligence courses into 235 schools , as extracurricular classes for grades 10 to 12 beginning February 2027, inside a global programme the vendor states has trained more than 600,000 South Africans. It is announced for a start five months beyond this window's close. No learner target, cost, funding split, teacher-training provision or certification pathway is published, and the 600,000 is the vendor's own figure . Extracurricular classes delivered by a vendor in one province is what the base holds on this indicator, and there is no national curriculum instrument beside it.	ADVANCED

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Training and skills	DT-related university facilities and qualifications	University research finds AI adoption in teaching and assessment outpacing institutional policy, with lecturers reporting inconsistent or absent guidance and no sector instrument held. 2026-08-17 — research from a South African university finds artificial-intelligence adoption in teaching and assessment outpacing institutional policy , with lecturers reporting inconsistent or absent guidance on accountability, on the reliability of detection tools and on academic integrity. No sector-wide instrument and no regulator guidance is held, and nothing in the twelve months to 2026-08-26 produces one. What the base holds on university capability is therefore a finding about the absence of governance rather than any measure of facilities, enrolment or qualifications — which are not on this ledger at all.	NO CHANGE
Training and skills	Graduates entering DT ecosystem	A skills fund went to year-round applications with 97% of 1,800 participants absorbed into employment, while the 2020 national strategy is under review with no replacement. 2026-08-25 — a R200m skills fund dropped its fixed application windows for year-round applications, having taken more than 1,800 young people across all nine provinces, 97% of them absorbed into employment and over 75% still employed after six months , against operator targets of 40,000 digitally skilled workers a year by 2030. 2026-07-23 — the strategy did not move: the 2020 national digital and future skills strategy is under comprehensive review with no replacement , disclosed in a written parliamentary reply rather than announced, alongside a national competency framework still in development. The department declined to forecast artificial intelligence's net employment effect. 2026-07-22 — and the institution that funds sector skills was referred for a governance assessment . The measurement of the gap is now better than the response to it. Employers report about 7% of ICT and engineering posts unfilled, with software developers, network engineers and security specialists hardest to fill, and attribute the gap 26% to basic-level training, 24% to graduate pipeline throughput and 21% to the pace of technological change , in a development bank report produced with the higher education department .	MIXED the delivery programmes moved and the national strategy did not

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Research institutions	Think tanks and academic departments contributing to DT policy	The country places 18th worldwide and is the only African country in the top 20 for digital-privacy research output, on a review of 4,760 articles from 2005 to 2025. 2026-08-18 — a bibliometric analysis of 4,760 articles over twenty years places the country 18th worldwide and the only African country in the top 20 for digital-privacy research output . It is the one place on this ledger where the country ranks near the top of anything. Two qualifications carried by the same review. It measures volume of output, not the coverage of the populations most exposed — refugees, people with disabilities, older people and racial and ethnic minorities are found notably underrepresented in that literature. And it is a first measurement here, with no earlier standing on the base to compare, so the level is stated and the direction is not. What the base does not hold is any link from that research capacity to policy: no research council submission, advisory panel or commissioned study appears in the instruments recorded elsewhere in this report.	NO CHANGE first measured in this window with nothing before it to compare

Inclusion

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Access to services	Citizen feedback portals		NO EVIDENCE
Access to services	Citizen participation in policy	A civil-society coalition asked the rights commission to halt data-centre developments pending transparent public participation; no participation process or commission response is on record. 2026-08-10 — a climate justice coalition submitted concerns to the human rights commission calling for a halt on data-centre developments pending transparent public participation , citing strain on scarce water, land and electricity. No participation process, commission response or moratorium is on record. The route it took is the finding. There is no statutory participation step for these approvals to attach to, so the objection was lodged with a rights body rather than a planning or energy regulator, and it arrived alongside the commission's own call for submissions . Participation happening through a human rights complaint is a description of what the ordinary process does not provide.	ADVANCED
Access to services	Gender equity		NO EVIDENCE

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Access to services	Inclusion of persons with disabilities	A seven-point plan on disability-inclusive data, universal design and AI-enabled assistive technology was agreed on 12 August 2026, anchored in a proposed centre of excellence. 2026-08-12 — a seven-point plan was agreed with a bilateral partner to deepen cooperation on disability-inclusive data, universal design and artificial-intelligence-enabled assistive technology , anchored in a proposed disability centre of excellence working with the national statistics office. No instrument, funding, timetable or data-sharing arrangement is published for cooperation that names the national statistics office as a partner, which is the gap worth naming: an agreement about disability data with a foreign partner, and no domestic statement of what data would be collected, held or shared. It is also the only disability-related digital instrument on this ledger.	ADVANCED
Access to services	Inclusion of refugees and IDPs		NO EVIDENCE
Digital divides	Bridging of digital divides	No analogue switch-off date is set, sixteen years past the original deadline, and the base cannot reconcile how many households are still analogue-dependent. 2026-08-14 — the department told Parliament that no date has been set for analogue television switch-off , sixteen years past the original 2010 deadline. The more useful finding is that nobody agrees how large the affected population is. Estimates of households still dependent on analogue range from about 500,000 on one civil-society account to between 2.2m and 4.5m on two others , and the record reconciles none of them. A ninefold spread in the count of the people a policy is for is a measurement failure before it is a delivery failure, and it is the clearest instance of the divide being unmeasured rather than unaddressed. No digital inclusion strategy instrument and no national digital literacy measurement appears anywhere on this ledger.	NO CHANGE

Data

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
National statistics	National strategy for development of statistics		NO EVIDENCE
National statistics	Censuses and surveys		NO EVIDENCE
National statistics	Statistics from administrative data		NO EVIDENCE

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
Open data	Use of open data	A national broadband map was launched on 31 March 2026 and is recorded as not public, so the gaps it reveals are visible to its holders and not to anyone else. 2026-03-31 — a national broadband map was launched , the first the country has held, and the ledger records it as implemented but not public. That combination is the whole of the finding. A map that identifies where coverage is absent is the input every subsequent decision needs — the connectivity programmes, the spectrum release, the rapid-deployment by-law reported elsewhere in this report — and none of those decisions can be scrutinised against it while it stays closed. The regulator's draft infrastructure database would compel operators to submit geo-referenced passive-infrastructure data twice a year , which would deepen the same holding without changing who can see it. The one open instrument on the ledger is narrower: an open science policy covering publicly funded research output, with no commencement date stated.	ADVANCED a national map built and not published
Use of satellite data	Agricultural use of satellite data		NO EVIDENCE
Use of satellite data	Meteorological use of satellite data		NO EVIDENCE

Geopolitics

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
US / hyperscaler activities	USA / hyperscaler MoUs, engagements and commitments	The state's public-service chatbot runs on a US company's open-weight models under a partnership with it, and voter registration ran inside the same company's messaging platform. Two state functions moved onto one foreign platform company inside three days of each other. The public service department's chatbot is a partnership with that company and a local supplier, built on its open-weight model family , serving policy, circular and legislation lookups to citizens and public servants. The electoral commission ran voter registration inside its messaging platform for the three days before the deadline, carrying one-time-password authentication, identity-document upload and address verification, and 1.7m registration transactions over the final weekend. Neither is a signed public commitment of the kind this indicator usually records, and that is the point: no memorandum, contract value, data-handling statement or exit arrangement is published for either. What the base holds is two live dependencies and no instrument behind them. Separately, the enterprise AI adoption reported under sectoral systems runs on a foreign cloud provider, and the satellite entrants reported under connectivity are the same country's.	ADVANCED

TOPIC	INDICATOR	DEVELOPMENTS	PROGRESS
China activities	Chinese MoUs, engagements and commitments	A domestic bank went live on China's cross-border payment system and was jointly authorised as renminbi clearing bank for Africa; a disability-data plan was agreed. 2025-11-20 — a domestic bank went live as the first African direct participant in China's cross-border interbank payment system, inaugurated at the central bank with both countries' central bank governors present. 2026-06-26 — the same bank and a Chinese state bank were jointly authorised as renminbi clearing bank for Africa , covering the nineteen African countries where the group operates. The designation was made by one foreign central bank with no African regulator party to it. 2026-08-12 — outside payments, a seven-point plan on disability-inclusive data, universal design and assistive technology was agreed , naming the national statistics office as a partner with no instrument or data-sharing arrangement published. The engagement is deepest where it is least visible as policy: the payments arrangements are commercial acts by a listed bank, authorised abroad, and no domestic instrument records or governs them.	ADVANCED
EU activities	EU MoUs, engagements and commitments		NO EVIDENCE
Gulf/UAE activities	Gulf MoUs, engagements and commitments		NO EVIDENCE
India activities	India MoUs, engagements and commitments		NO EVIDENCE

Where the record is thin

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT	LAST PROBED
Data-centre incentive instrument (SEZ, depreciation, grid priority)	—	not yet probed
Education management information systems	—	not yet probed
Electronic death registration system	—	not yet probed
Cross-border transfer adequacy determinations	—	not yet probed
Malabo Convention ratification position	—	not yet probed
AfCFTA Digital Trade Protocol domestication	—	not yet probed
Rules governing state automated decision-making	—	not yet probed
AI incident or assurance register	—	not yet probed
Digital inclusion strategy instrument	—	not yet probed

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT	LAST PROBED
National digital literacy measurement	—	not yet probed
Municipal ICT expenditure data	—	not yet probed
Innovation spectrum, lower 6GHz	The gazette notice releasing lower-6 GHz innovation spectrum, or an ICASA decision or licence record naming it.	2026-08-14
District Health Information System	A National Department of Health statement, annual report or tender record for the District Health Information System, including the hosting arrangement put out to tender in 2026-07.	2026-08-14
Non-bank payment service provider licensing	The National Payment System Act amendment bill or a SARB directive establishing a licensing regime for non-bank payment service providers.	2026-08-14
SAMOS real-time gross settlement	A South African Reserve Bank statement, annual report or system document on SAMOS, which the base carries no source for at any date.	2026-08-14
Cybercrimes Act	The gazetted Cybercrimes Act 19 of 2020 with its commencement proclamation, or a prosecution or enforcement record under it.	2026-08-14
Information Regulator appropriation	The Information Regulator's annual report or the Justice vote's appropriation line naming its allocation.	2026-08-14
Expert review panel	The ministerial notice or departmental statement appointing the expert review panel and naming its members and terms of reference.	2026-08-14
Prudential Authority AI and cloud supervision standards	A Prudential Authority directive, guidance note or consultation paper on artificial-intelligence and cloud supervision standards.	2026-08-14
Sector-level AI strategies	A departmental or sector-regulator statement naming a sector-level artificial-intelligence strategy and its status.	2026-08-14
Analogue television switch-off date	a gazetted or ministerially announced switch-off date, or a departmental statement of the criteria and household threshold that would set one	2026-08-14
Institutional policy on artificial intelligence in higher education	a sector instrument from the higher education department or the quality council, or a published institutional policy on artificial intelligence in teaching and assessment at a named university	2026-08-17
Public participation in data-centre approvals	A published public-participation procedure for data-centre siting or approval, or a commission or authority response to the coalition's submission.	2026-08-11

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